

Getting Your OpenRouter API Key

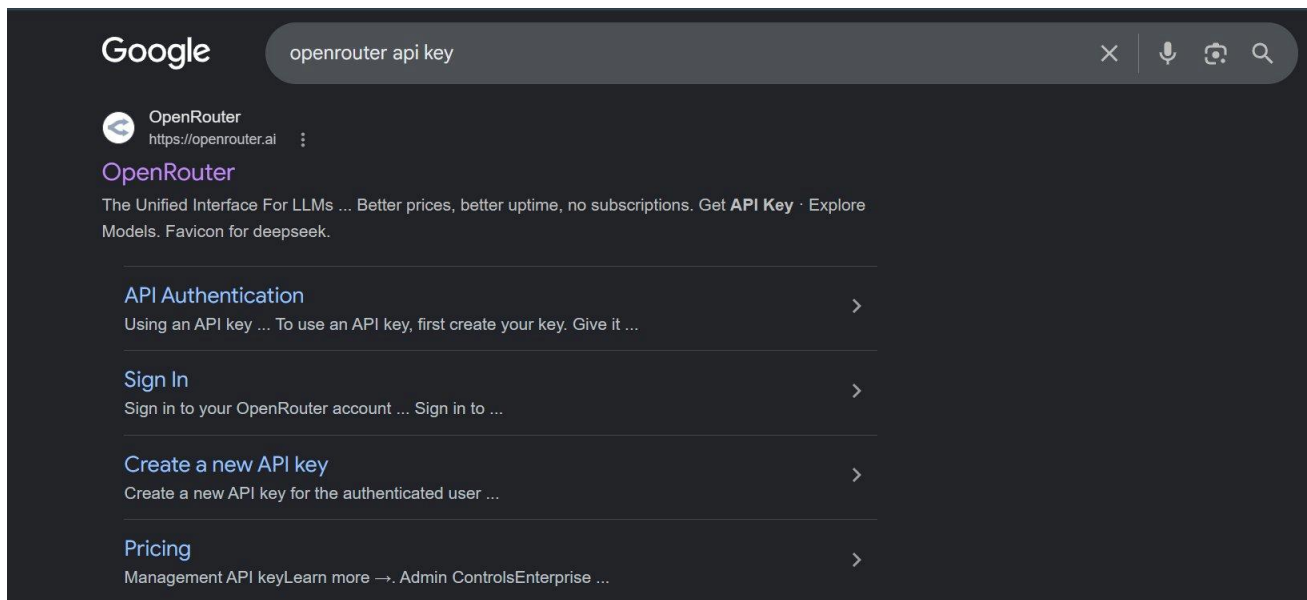
A simple walkthrough for adding it to Open WebUI

NOTE: IN ALL WALKTHROUGHS, MAKE SURE IF LOCAL MODELS ARE USED OR GEMINI (CLOUD BASED) IS USED. WHENEVER LOCAL MODELS ARE USED, DO NOT USE GEMINI MODELS OR THE OPEN ROUTER ONES.

PART 1 — GET YOUR OPENROUTER API KEY

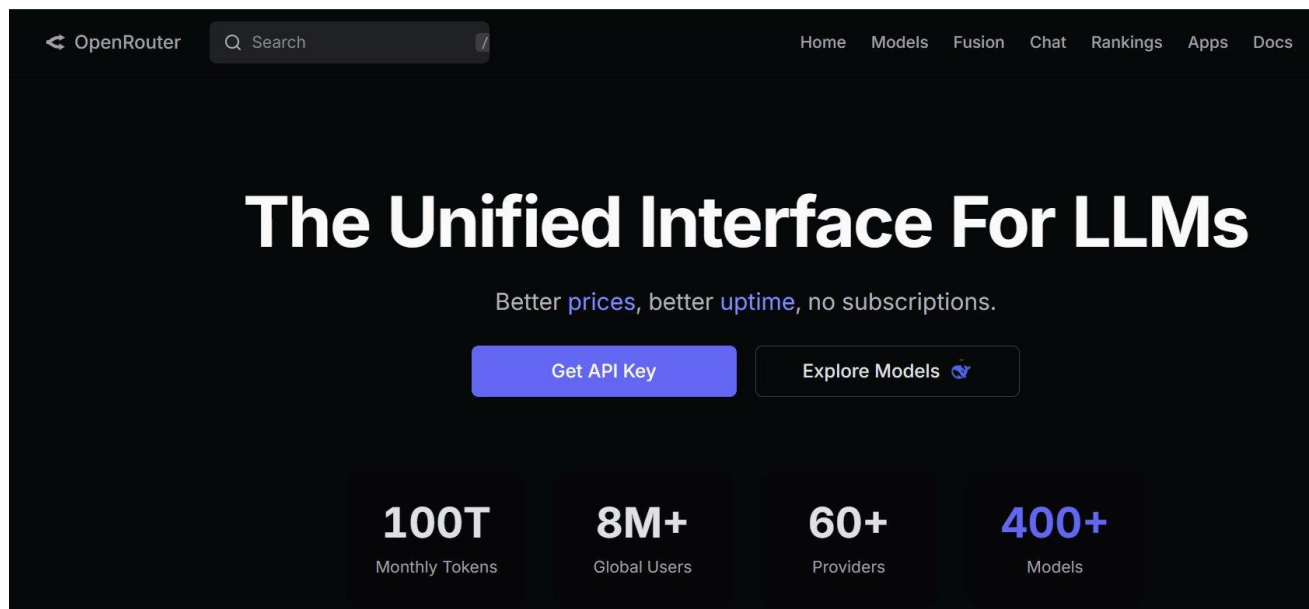
Step 1 — Go to openrouter.ai

Open your browser and search for "openrouter api key" or go directly to openrouter.ai. You'll land on their homepage.



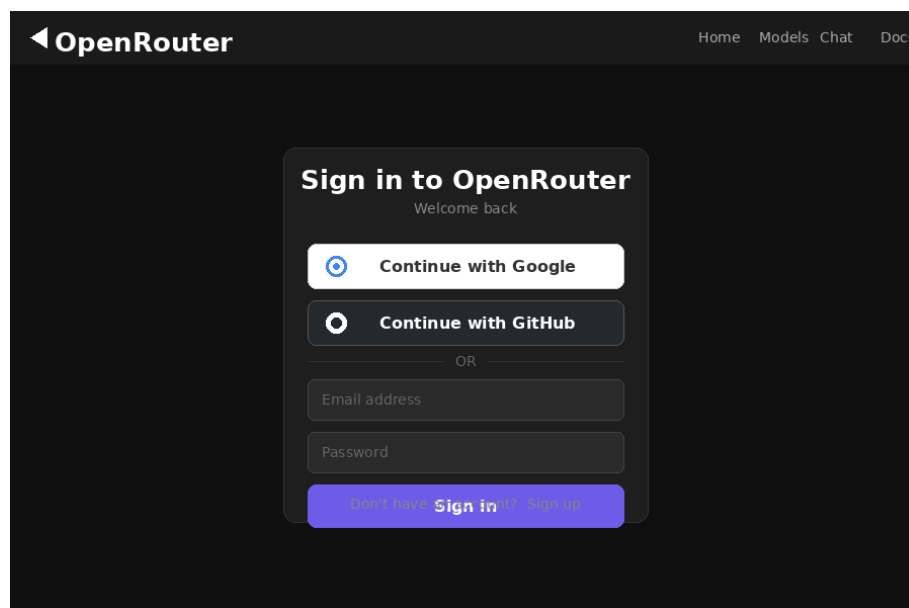
Step 2 — Click "Get API Key"

On the OpenRouter homepage, click the big purple "Get API Key" button. This will take you to the sign-in page if you're not already logged in.



Step 3 — Sign in to your account

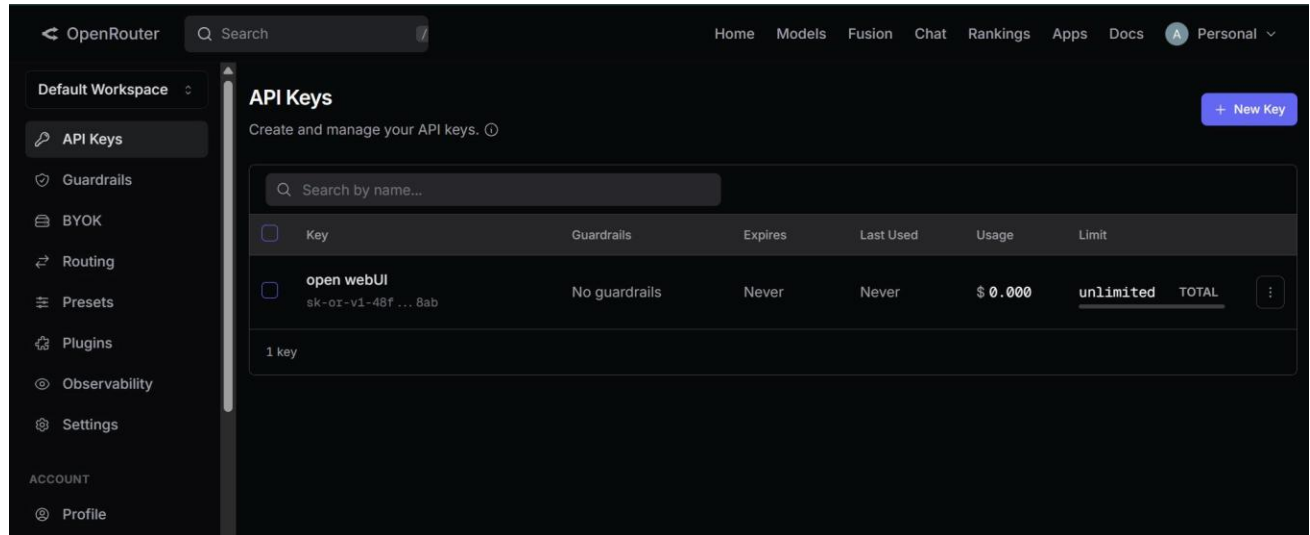
You'll be taken to the OpenRouter sign-in page. Log in with your Google account, GitHub account, or your email and password. If you don't have an account yet, click "Sign up" at the bottom — it's free.



💡 The quickest option is "Continue with Google" or "Continue with GitHub" — just one click, no password needed.

Step 4 — Go to the API Keys section

Once signed in, look at the left sidebar and click "API Keys". This is where all your keys are managed. You might already see one listed here — that's fine.



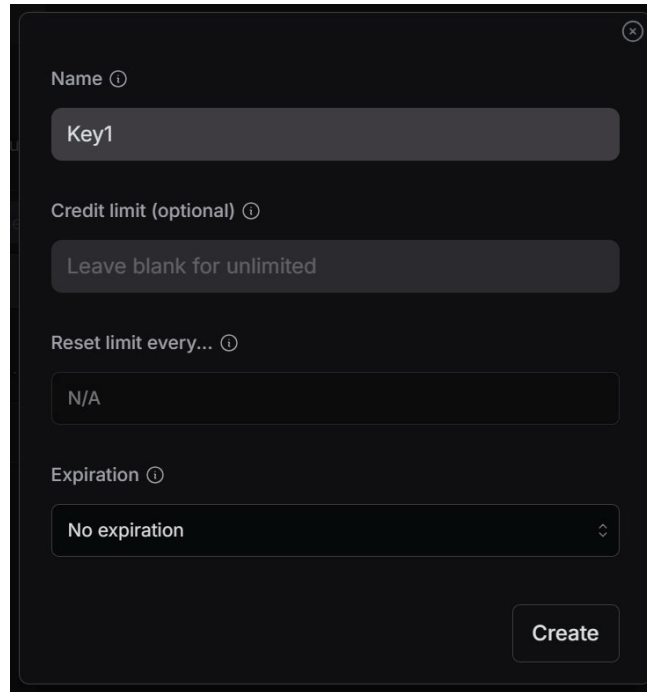
Step 5 — Click "+ New Key"

Hit the "+ New Key" button in the top right corner. A small dialog box will pop up asking for a few details.

A screenshot of a modal dialog box for creating a new API key. It has a close button in the top right corner. The form contains four fields: "Name" with a placeholder "e.g. 'Chatbot Key'", "Credit limit (optional)" with a placeholder "Leave blank for unlimited", "Reset limit every..." with a placeholder "N/A", and "Expiration" with a dropdown menu showing "No expiration". A "Create" button is at the bottom right.

Step 6 — Name your key and click "Create"

Give your key a simple name like "Key1" or "My WebUI Key". Leave the credit limit blank (unlimited) and expiration as "No expiration". Then click Create.

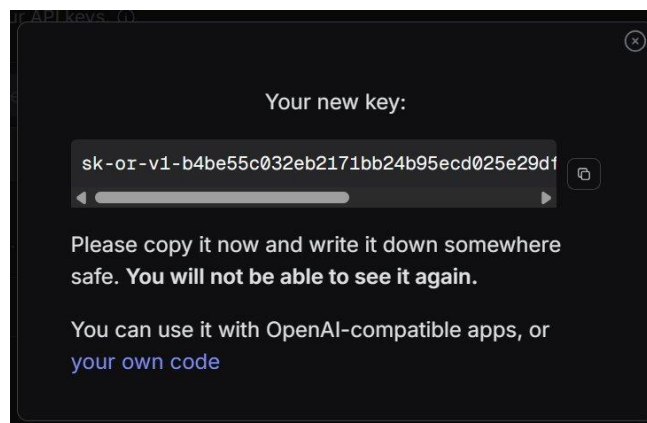


A dark-themed form for creating an OpenAI API key. It has a close button in the top right corner. The form contains four sections: 'Name' with a text input containing 'Key1'; 'Credit limit (optional)' with a text input containing 'Leave blank for unlimited'; 'Reset limit every...' with a text input containing 'N/A'; and 'Expiration' with a dropdown menu showing 'No expiration'. A 'Create' button is at the bottom right.

💡 You don't need to change any other settings — the defaults are totally fine for personal use.

Step 7 — Copy your key immediately!

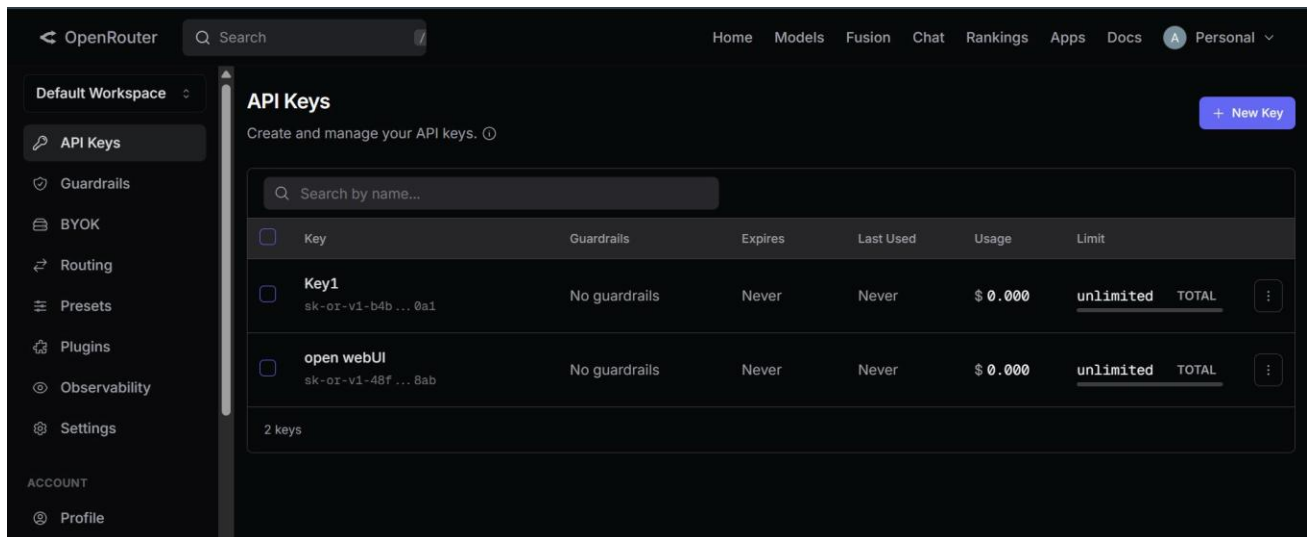
Your new API key is shown just once. It looks like: `sk-or-v1-b4be55c0...` Copy it right now and paste it somewhere safe like a notes app or password manager.



⚠️ OpenRouter hides this key forever once you close the popup. If you lose it, just delete it and create a new one — no big deal.

Step 8 — Key created — you're done on OpenRouter

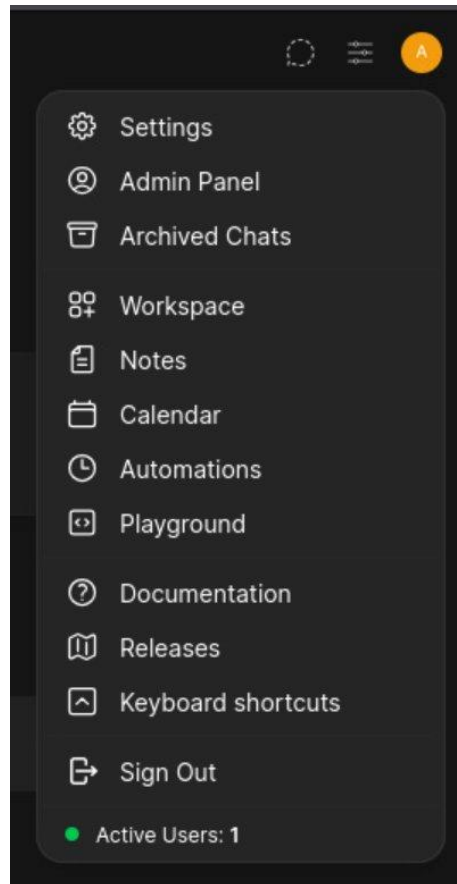
Your new key will now appear in the API Keys dashboard. The value is hidden (only the last few characters show). You're all set — now head over to Open WebUI.



PART 2 — ADD THE KEY TO OPEN WEBUI

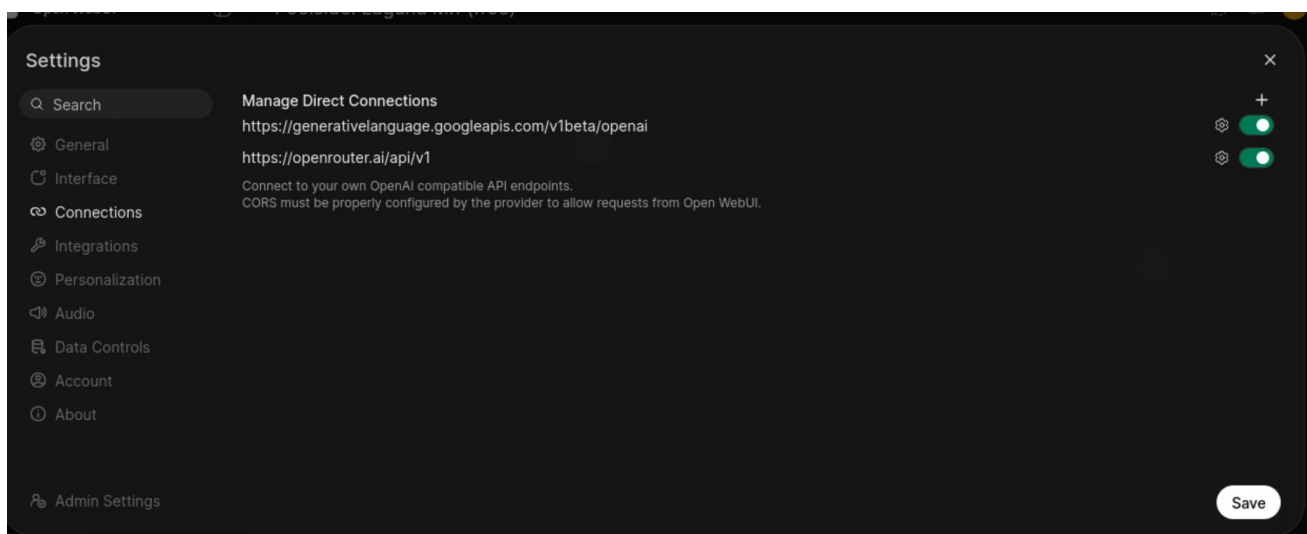
Step 1 — Open your user menu and go to Settings

In Open WebUI, click your profile icon in the top right corner. A menu will drop down — click "Settings" at the top of the list.



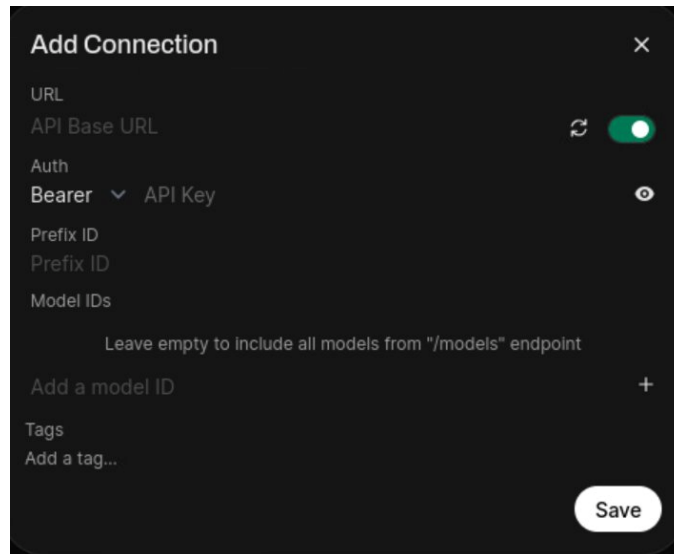
Step 2 — Click "Connections" in the sidebar

Inside Settings, click "Connections" in the left sidebar. You'll see the "Manage Direct Connections" section. Click the "+" button on the right to add a new connection.



Step 3 — Fill in the URL and API Key fields

An "Add Connection" dialog will appear. In the URL field enter: `https://openrouter.ai/api/v1` — then click in the API Key field next to "Bearer" and paste your OpenRouter key.



Add Connection [X]

URL

API Base URL [Refresh] [On]

Auth

Bearer [v] API Key [Eye]

Prefix ID

Prefix ID

Model IDs

Leave empty to include all models from "/models" endpoint

Add a model ID [+]

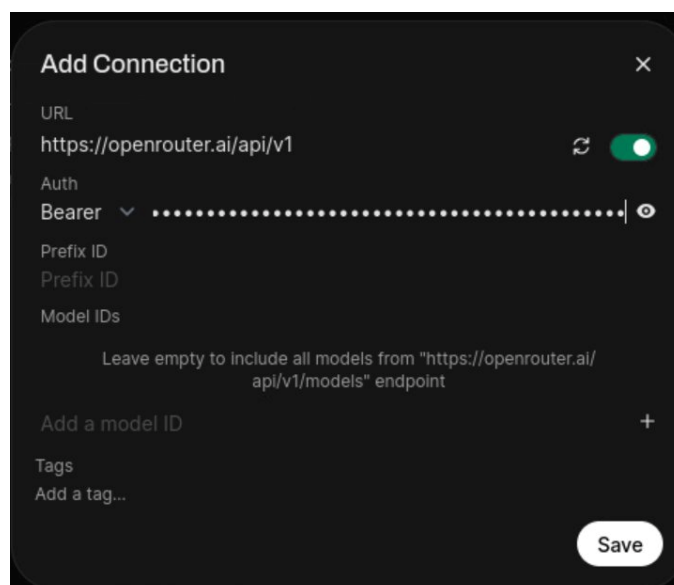
Tags

Add a tag...

Save

Step 4 — Save and confirm the connection

Once filled in, the URL shows `https://openrouter.ai/api/v1` and the API Key field shows dots (hidden for security). Hit "Save" and Open WebUI will connect to OpenRouter.



Add Connection [X]

URL

`https://openrouter.ai/api/v1` [Refresh] [On]

Auth

Bearer [v] [Eye]

Prefix ID

Prefix ID

Model IDs

Leave empty to include all models from "https://openrouter.ai/api/v1/models" endpoint

Add a model ID [+]

Tags

Add a tag...

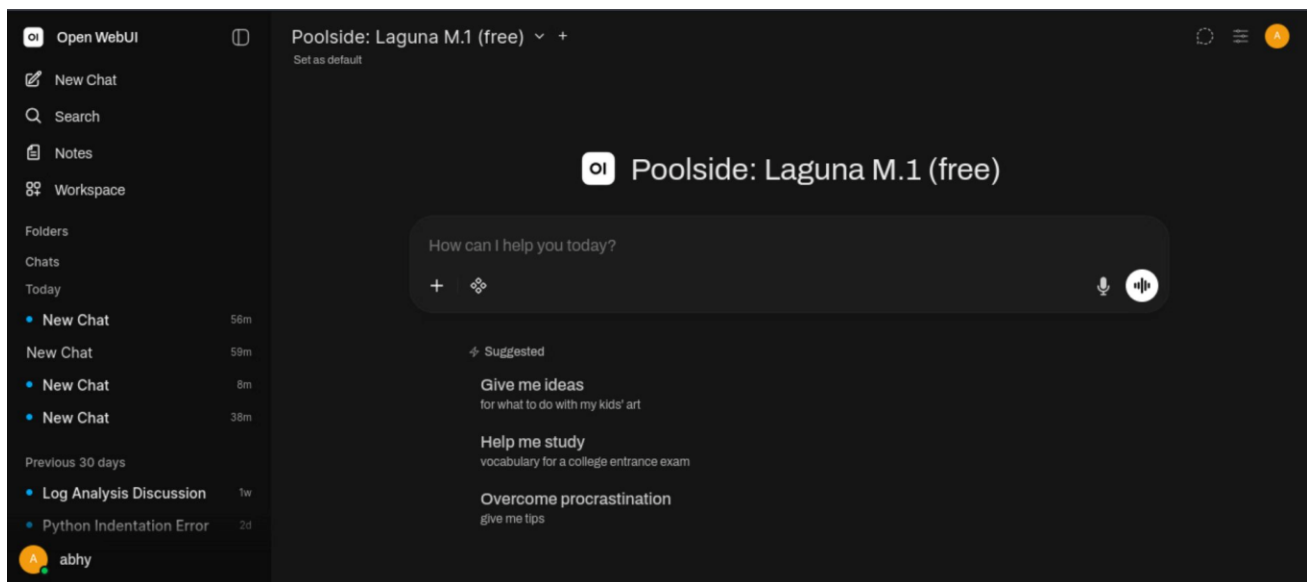
Save

💡 Leave "Model IDs" blank to automatically get all available models from OpenRouter.

PART 3 — START CHATTING WITH A MODEL

Step 1 — Select a model and start chatting

Go back to the main Open WebUI screen. Click the model name at the top of the chat window — a dropdown will appear showing all the models pulled in from OpenRouter. Pick one and you're good to go! In the example below, "Poolside: Laguna M.1 (free)" is selected and ready to use.



💡 Models with "(free)" in the name cost nothing to use — great for getting started.

📖 Want to use a different model? You can browse all available models at openrouter.ai/models and filter by price, capability, or context length. Just search for the model name in the Open WebUI dropdown — if it's connected through OpenRouter, it'll be there. Some models are free, others are pay-per-use, so check the pricing before picking one for heavy use.

Select only free models, not all free models will work. The famous ones will give rate limit error.

So be patient when selecting and working with free models.

The model chosen above will work in most cases.

50 prompts per day are allowed with free API key.